

- This means there is investment earmarked for productions like *Peaky Blinders* that are shot and produced, as well as being set, in an under-represented part of the UK. However, it remains a popular mainstream show, with international sales potential.
- As television becomes more of a global industry, **international co-productions** are becoming common. Netflix has ‘rescued’ many BBC productions like *The Last Kingdom*, providing a cash injection for struggling titles. BBC has also collaborated extensively with cable and streaming channel HBO on big budget shows like *His Dark Materials*.
- The BBC has a global reputation as a **quality media brand** which less well-known channels/platforms would be eager to collaborate with. While most UK-produced content is distributed by BBC America, *Peaky Blinders* is the exception.
- Netflix is the number one **streaming** service – as of 2022 they have over 200 million paid subscribers, with 37 million joining in the previous year. They have invested heavily in original content, but also commissioning or buying existing shows from **non-Anglophone** territories. 80% of content commissioned in 2021 was from outside the US and Canada.
- Shows like *Squid Game* (South Korea), *Lupin* (France) and *Money Heist* (Spain) have been huge successes in different territories and crucially offering very different content to the franchise-heavy titles of rival channels like Disney+.

Consider recent technological change and media production, distribution and circulation and the impact of digitally convergent media platforms.

- The popularity of online streaming services means that audience viewing figures for a scheduled broadcast are no longer the main indicator of a TV show’s success.
- Season 6 of *Peaky Blinders* had 5.42 million viewers in the UK when it premiered on BBC 1 in April 2022. When it premiered on Netflix in

June 2022, it had 45.71 million hours of playing time in just one week (making it the second most popular title after *Stranger Things*).

- Fans from around the world – from Korea to Argentina – dress up in *Peaky Blinders* cosplay and share videos on social networking apps like TikTok, indicating the global reach of the show.

Consider theoretical approaches

Cultural industries – Hesmondhalgh:

- One of Hesmondhalgh’s key ideas is that cultural industries are different to other manufacturers. Media texts are purchased usually just once, and then continually re-used rather than wearing out and having to be replaced. This means IP (intellectual property) and the range of products using it must be sold (and re-sold in different forms) to maintain a profit. This leads to heavy investment in familiar products (including stars) and less experimentation.
- The BBC is free from these constraints, as is Netflix (which is **subscription based**). Both institutions need to make entertaining shows that engage with a range of audiences – so they still need to appeal to fans of genres, particular stars and directors. However, unlike TV channels using a commercial model (where shows can be cancelled mid-season if the audience figures aren’t high enough for advertisers), they have more opportunity for experimentation and taking risks.

PART 4: STARTING POINTS – Audiences

How media products target, attract, reach, address and potentially construct audiences.

- *Peaky Blinders* offers several **audience pleasures** that targets a diverse range of viewers.
- Fans of the gangster or even Western genre would enjoy the clear genre conventions being used and innovated upon. Audiences who enjoy historical dramas – both for educational purposes and for visual spectacle – would enjoy the lavish production design and unique fashions.